

Session 18: Jacob's Journey to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Averting crisis with the family moving to Egypt, the final third of the Yoseph story highlights the tension of temporary safety outside the land of promise.
- Upon hearing the news that Yoseph is alive, Yaaqov metaphorically dies, coming back to life when he believes the news. This foreshadows a future-looking hope of return to the land and new creation life.
- The list of the 70 nations in Genesis 10 and the 70 descendants of Yaaqov are connected. The fate of the nations is bound up with the fate of the family of Israel.

Yoseph Rescues Egypt and His Family

Genesis 45:25b-47:31 The Remnant of Yaaqov Is Rescued in Egypt				Genesis 48:1-49:28 Yaaqov Blesses His Seed		Genesis 49:29-50:26 Death in Egypt, Forgiveness, and the Ascent to Canaan		
45:25b-46:30 Yaaqov and 70 family go down to Egypt	46:31-47:11 Pharaoh and Yoseph settle Yaaqov's family in Goshen during the 7-year famine	47:12-27 Yoseph keeps family and nations alive during the 7-year famine	47:28-31 Yaaqov lives 10+ years in Egypt, requests burial in Canaan	48:1-22 Yaaqov adopts and blesses Yoseph's 2 sons + Inversion of birth order	49:1-28 Yaaqov blesses or curses 12 sons + Inversion of birth order + Yehudah made ruler	49:29-50:14 Yaaqov requests burial in Canaan + 70 days of weeping + Yoseph "goes up" to bury Yaaqov in Canaan	50:15-21 Yoseph forgives and reconciles with brothers	50:22-26 Yoseph requests burial in Canaan + Swears an oath

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 45:25b- 47:31
45:25b-46:30 • Ya'akov and 70 (שבע) family members go down (יָרַד) to Goshen-Egypt
46:31-47:27 • 46:31-47:11 Yoseph provides food and settles his family in Goshen during the 7-year famine • 47:12-27 Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt during the 7-year famine
47:28-31 • Ya'akov lives 10 + 7 years (שבע) in Egypt • Ya'akov makes Yoseph swear an oath (שבע) that he be buried in Canaan

Genesis 48:1-49:28

- **48:1-22** Ya'akov adopts and blesses Yoseph's two sons
- **49:1-28** Ya'akov blesses or curses his 12 sons

Genesis 49:29- 50:26

49:29-50:14

- **Ya'akov requests his burial in Canaan**
- Ya'akov dies + **70 (שבע)** days of weeping
- Yoseph makes the brothers **go up (עלה)** to Canaan **to bury Ya'akov**

50:15-21

- Yoseph forgives and reconciles with his brothers

50:22-26

- **Yoseph** makes family **swear an oath (שבע)** **that he be buried in Canaan**

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This final act of the story of Yaaqov's sons is also the final act of the Genesis scroll as a whole. It has been designed with three main parts.

- In part 1 (Gen. 45:25b-47:31), Yaaqov and his family go down to Egypt where they are rescued from the famine and where Yaaqov makes his request to be buried in Canaan.
- In part 2 (Gen. 48:1-49:28), Yaaqov offers blessings and curses for his sons and grandsons, passing on the covenant promise to the next generation.
- In part 3 (Gen. 49:29-50:26), Yaaqov again requests a burial in Canaan and then dies.

Notice the symmetrical design of the various parts of this composition.

- The section opens and closes with a focus on the burials of Yaaqov and Yoseph, both related to a covenant oath of future burial in the land.
- In the center are the blessings for the next generation and beyond.
- The middle unit of the opening and closing parts (Gen. 46:31-47:11 and 50:15-21) both involve Yoseph providing food for his brothers and forgiving them and setting them up well in the land of Egypt.

Yaaqov and His Family Descend to Egypt

Genesis 45:25b-46:30

45:25b-28

The Brothers Come From Egypt to Ya'akov in Canaan

- The brothers "came to the land of Canaan, to Ya'akov their father"
- "Yoseph is still **alive!** ... **I will see him before I die!**"

46:1-27

- **46:1-7** Ya'akov's vision of Yahweh at Be'er-**Sheva'** (שבַּע)
- **46:7-27** List of Ya'akov's **70** (שבע) descendants who went to Egypt

46:28-30

The Brothers and Ya'akov Come to Yoseph in Egypt

- The brothers and Ya'akov come to the land of Goshen to meet Yoseph"
- "I can **die** now, because I have seen your face, that you are **alive!**"

Genesis 46:31-47:27

46:31-47:11

Yoseph Settles His Brothers and Father in Goshen-Egypt

- **47:11** "and Yoseph gave them **a land-possession (אֲחֻזָּה) in the land of Egypt** "

47:12-26

- Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt by purchasing all the land

47:27

- "And they dwelt **in the land of Egypt and took possession (אָחֲזוּ) of it**"

Genesis 47:28-31

47:28

- Ya'akov lived in Egypt for **17 years** (שבע), and lived for a total of 140 + **7 years** (שבע)

47:29-30a

- Ya'akov requests to be buried back in Canaan with his fathers

47:30b-31

- Ya'akov makes Yoseph **swear an oath (שבוע)** to bury him in Canaan

Genesis 45:25-47:31. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In this first part of act 3, Yoseph's brothers arrive back in Canaan and report to Yaaqov that Yoseph is still alive. The entire part has been given a three-part symmetrical design.

- Unit 1 (Gen. 45:25b-46:30): Yoseph's brothers return to Yaaqov in Canaan and report that Yoseph is alive; Yaaqov wants to go down and see him before his own death.
- Unit 2 (Gen. 46:31-47:27): While in Egypt, the seven-year famine rages on, but Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt and for his own family in Goshen-Egypt.
- Unit 3 (Gen. 47:28-31): Now at the end of his life, Yaaqov requests that after he dies Yoseph bury him up in Canaan.

Yaaqov's Journey Down to Egypt

45:25b **And they came to the land of Canaan**, to **Ya'akov their father**,

²⁶ and they told him, saying,

"Yoseph is still alive!

And indeed, he is the ruler of all the land of Egypt!"

And **his heart stopped**, because he did not believe them.

²⁷ And they spoke to him all the words of Yoseph that he spoke to them,

and he saw **the carts which Yoseph had sent**,

and their father Ya'akov's breath-energy **came back to life**,

²⁸ and Yisra'el said,

"It more than enough that **Yoseph my son is alive**.

I will go and I will see him before **I die**."

46:1 And he set out, **Yisra'el and all that belonged to him**,

and he came to **Be'er-Sheva' (= Well of Seven)**,

and he sacrificed sacrifices to **the Elohim of his father Yitskhaq**.

² And Elohim said to Yisra'el in visions of the night,

and he said,

"Ya'akov, Ya'akov!"

And he said,

"Look, it's me!"

³ And he said,

"I am El, **the Elohim of your father**."

Don't be afraid to **go down to Egypt** ,
because I will set you up as a great nation there.

⁴ I will **go down with you to Egypt** ,
and I will make you go back up, indeed, a going up,
and Yoseph will set his hand on your eyes."

⁵ And Ya'akov got up from **Be'er-Sheva'** ,
and the sons of Yisra'el picked up Ya'akov their father,
and their children and their wives,
on **the carts that Phar'oh had sent** to carry him;
⁶ and they took their herds and all their possessions,
which they possessed in the land of Cana'an,
and they went to Egypt , Ya'akov and all of his seed with him:
⁷ his sons and the sons of his sons with him,
his daughters and the daughters of his sons,
and all his seed,
he brought with him to Egypt .

vv. 8-27: List of **70** descendants of Ya'akov "**who went to Egypt** "

²⁸ Now, he sent Yehudah before him to Yoseph,
to instruct before him toward Goshen,
and they came to the land of Goshen .
²⁹ And Yoseph bound up his chariot,
and he went up to meet **Yisra'el his father** in Goshen,
and he saw him,
and he fell upon his neck,
and he wept upon his neck even more.
³⁰ And Yisra'el said to Yoseph,
"**I can die** this time, after I have seen your face,
because **you are still alive** ."

Genesis 45:25-46:30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yaaqov's Death and Revival

This unit begins with a short paragraph about Yaaqov's response to the report that Yoseph, his beloved son, is still alive. Notice the interplay of "life" and "death" language and focus on Yaaqov's "death" and "revival" as he takes in this news.

a ²⁵ And they came to the land of Cana'an, to **Ya'akov** their father,
²⁶ and they told him, saying,

A b “Yoseph is still alive!
 And indeed, he is the ruler of all the land of Egypt!”
a' And **his heart stopped**, because he did not believe them.

B 27 And they spoke to him all the words of Yoseph that he spoke to them,
 and he saw the carts which Yoseph had sent,
 and their father Ya'akov's breath-energy **came back to life**.

A' a 28 And **Yisrael** said,
 b “It more than enough that **Yoseph my son is alive**.
 a' I will go and **I will see him** before **I die**.”

Genesis 45:25-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Notice how in this section, Yaakov undergoes a death and resurrection as he processes the news that his son Yoseph, presumed to be dead, is actually alive.

A - v. 26: “Yoseph is alive!” > “his heart stopped”

B - v. 27: Yaaqov sees and comes “back to life”

A' - v. 28: “Yoseph is alive!” > “I will see him before I die”

This short sequence is an important first statement of a key theme in this section about death and the hope for future life. Here Yaaqov metaphorically dies and is revived from that death. This anticipates the future moment when Yaaqov is going to literally die at the conclusion of this act (in Gen. 50). Yaaqov's “revival” is also a future anticipation of when he will be made to “go up” to be buried in Canaan in the cave of Makpelah, an Eden spot that is familiar to the reader from Genesis 23. The imagery of Yaaqov's body “going up” to an Eden burial is an important icon of the hope of resurrection in Genesis that will be drawn upon and developed by the later prophets (Ezek. 37 is a great example).

These images of Yaaqov's (a.k.a. Yisrael's) death and resurrection act as surrounding frames around the whole of this final act of the Genesis scroll.

Genesis 45:25b-30

- **45:26** Ya'akov metaphorically **"dies"** upon hearing that Yoseph is alive
- Ya'akov's spirit **"comes to life"** when he sees evidence that Yoseph is alive
- **45:28** "It is enough Yoseph my son is still alive; I will go and see him before **I die**"

Genesis 46:1-49:33

- Ya'akov and 70 descendants descend into Egyptian exile

Genesis Gen 50:1-26

- **49:33** Ya'akov actually **dies** at the end of his years
- **50** Yoseph leads a procession to **"make the bones of Ya'akov go up"** to be buried in the cave of Makpelah in Canaan

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Elohim informs Yaaqov that he will be descending to his death in Egypt, but that the divine presence will be with him and will bring up him up out of Egypt as well (Gen. 46:4). This revelation at Beersheba creates an important analogy between Yaaqov and his son that continues throughout the rest of the Genesis scroll.

- Yoseph goes down into a pit (בור) and to Egypt // "going down" (ירד) into the grave.
- Yahweh was with Yoseph in Egypt (Gen. 39:2, 21).
- Yoseph was elevated out of the pit (בור) and up over Egypt // "alive from the dead" (Gen. 45:28).
- Yaaqov will go down (ירד) to Egypt and will die there.
- Yahweh will be with Yaaqov in Egypt (Gen. 46:4).
- Yahweh will make Yaaqov "go up" (עלה) from Egypt.

Yaaqov as a New Abraham and Isaac

In Genesis 46:1-5, Yaaqov's vision in Beersheba is set on analogy with similar visions and altars built in this very spot by Isaac and Abraham.

Yaaqov at Beersheba	Isaac at Beersheba	Abraham at Beersheba
Gen. 46:1-4 So Yisrael set out with all that he had, and came to Beersheba , and offered sacrifices (ויזבח זבחים) to the God of his father Isaac . God spoke to Israel in visions of the night and said, "Yaaqov, Yaaqov." And he said, "Here I am." He said, " I am God, the God of your father ; do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for I will make you a great nation there. " I will go down with you to Egypt, and I will also surely bring you up again; and Yoseph will close your eyes."	Gen. 26:23-25 Then [Isaac] went up from there to Beersheba . The Lord appeared to him the same night and said, " I am the God of your father Abraham ; Do not fear , for I am with you . I will bless you, and multiply your seed , For the sake of my servant Abraham." And he built an altar (מזבח) there ...	Gen. 22:11, 17-19 "Abraham, Abraham." And he said, "Here I am!" ... indeed I will greatly bless you, and I will greatly multiply your seed because you have obeyed my voice." So Abraham went ... to Beersheba; and Abraham lived at Beersheba .
<i>Jacob, Isaac, and Abraham at Beersheba. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

Beersheba was where Abraham settled after his great act of obedience in Genesis 22, and Beersheba was where Isaac settled after God explicitly told him not to go to Egypt (Gen. 26:2).

The divine summons "Yaaqov, Yaaqov!" recalls the same summons given to Abraham in the moment his act of greatest obedience (Gen. 22:11). In Genesis 22, Abraham has just given away his beloved son, while in Genesis 46, Yaaqov is about to receive back his beloved son.

The Goshen-Garden in Egypt

When Yoseph invites his father and family to come down to Egypt, he has prepared a special place for them called "Goshen" (Gen. 45:10; 46:28-29, 34; 47:1-4, 6, 27).

Geographically, Goshen was a rural region outside of the main urban areas of Egypt's cities. The importance of Goshen's location on the outskirts of Egypt will play an important role in Genesis 47.

In these passages, Goshen is described as:

- A place where Yaakqov and his family "can be near" Yoseph and have their needs provided for (Gen. 45:10-11).
- A place where Yoseph's brothers can shepherd their flocks in peace (Gen. 47:1-4).

- A place where one can enjoy the “good of the land” (Gen. 47:6).
- A place where Yaaqov’s family can experience Elohim’s blessing (Gen. 47:27).

Isn’t it interesting that the first and last letters of the Hebrew word “Goshen” spell the Hebrew word for “garden”?

English: Garden

Hebrew: **g** a **n** / גן

English: “Goshen”

Hebrew: **g** oshe **n** / גושן

“Goshen” is Israel's Eden-ark refuge during the time of famine, and they will remain there until the years of famine are over so they can be delivered from their exile and restored to the promised land.

Yehudah the Leader of the Tribes

In Genesis 46:28, the narrator highlights Yehudah’s role in leading the seed of Yaaqov down into Egypt, specifically “instructing them to Goshen.” This prominent role for Yehudah among the brothers has been strategically placed here to match the other significant moments in Genesis 37-50 that highlight Yehudah’s role among his brothers.

Genesis 37:2-41:57			Genesis 42:1-45:25a			Genesis 45:25b-50:26		
37:2-36 Yoseph and Yaaqov descend to Egypt/pit/grave because of brothers' deception	38:1-30 Yehudah's 2 sons die, 2 sons born + Royal "staff"	39:1-41:57 Yoseph elevated as ruler of Egypt + Plan to rescue from 7 years of famine + Divide land into fifths	42:1-38 Brothers descend to Egypt + Tested by Yoseph	43:1-44:34 Brothers tested by Yoseph + Binyamin taken + Yehudah offers himself as a sacrifice	45:1-25a Yoseph sends brothers back to Yaaqov	45:25b-47:31 Yoseph ruler of Egypt enacts plan to rescue from 7 years of famine + Divide land into fifths	48:1-49:28 Yaaqov adopts 2 sons + Blesses many + Yehudah's royal "staff"	49:29-50:26 Brothers forgiven + Yaaqov ascends from grave to Canaan + Yoseph hopes to ascend

Genesis 37:2-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yehudah is mentioned in the first two literary units of Genesis 37-41, and these two roles of Yehudah are symmetrically matched by his position and role in Genesis 45-50.

- In Genesis 37, Yehudah betrays Yoseph, which leads Yoseph down to Egypt. // In Genesis 46, Yehudah leads his entire family down to Yoseph in Egypt.
- In Genesis 38, Yehudah’s staff and future seed are rescued from death. // In Genesis 49, Yehudah is elevated to the position of royal firstborn in the family, and his future seed will rule the nations.
- In Genesis 43-44, the center of the entire act is Yehudah’s self-giving offer of his own life in place of the beloved Binyamin.

Altogether, these stories about Yehudah paint a powerful portrait of the future messianic ruler from the line of Yehudah. After Yehudah’s two failures, he is given a double role of honor and royal exaltation, not just for himself, but as a pointer to his future seed who will rule over the nations. But that future royal rule is qualified by the story of Yehudah’s greatest act, which was to lay down his life for his brother, which opened up the pathway to life and blessing for others.

The 70 From Yaaqov and From Noah

⁸ And these are the names of the sons of Yisra'el

who went to Egypt,

Ya'akov and his sons:

Reuven was the firstborn of Ya'akov.

⁹ And the sons of Reuven:

Khanokh and Paul' and Khetzron and Karmi.

¹⁰ And the sons of **Shim'on** :

Yemu'el and Yamin and Ohad and Yakhin and Tzokhar and Sha'ul son of a Canaanite woman.

¹¹ And the sons of **Levi** :

Gershon, Qohath, and Merry.

¹² And the sons of **Yehudah** :

'Er and 'Onan and Shelah and Peretz and Zerakh.

And 'Er and 'Onan died in the land of Canaan,

and the sons of Peretz were Khetzron and Khamul.

¹³ And the sons of **Yissakhar** :

Tola' and Puwwah and Yov and Shimron.

¹⁴ And the sons of **Zevulun** :

Sered and Elon and Yakhle'el.

¹⁵ **These are the sons of Le'ah**, whom she birthed for Ya'akov in the land of Paddan-Aram, and also **Dinah** his daughter.

All the lives of his sons and daughters were thirty-three .

¹⁶ And the sons of **Gad** :

Tziphyon and Khaggi and Shuni and Etzbon, Eri and Arodi and Ar'eli.

¹⁷ And the sons of **Asher** :

Yimnah and Yishwah and Yishwi and Beriyah, and Serakh their sister.

And the sons of Beriyah were Kheber and Malki'el.

¹⁸ **These are the sons of Zilpah**, whom Lavan gave to Le'ah his daughter, and she birthed these for Ya'akov, **sixteen lives** .

¹⁹ **The sons of Rakhel**, wife of Ya'akov:

Yoseph and **Binyamin** .

²⁰ And there were born for Yoseph in the land of Egypt

the ones whom Asenath daughter of Potiphera priest of 'On birthed for him,

Manasseh and Ephraim.

²¹ And the sons of Binyamin:

Bela' and Bekor and Eshbal, Gera and Na'aman, Ekhi and Ro'sh, Muppim and Khuppim and Ard.

²² **These are the sons of Rakhel** whom she birthed for Ya'akov: every life, **fourteen** .

23 And the sons of **Dan** : Khushim.

24 And the sons of **Naphtali** :

Yakhtze'el and Guniy and Yetzer and Shillem.

25 These are **the sons of Bilhah** whom Lavan gave to Rakhel his daughter, and she bore these for Ya'akov: every life, **seven** .

26 And every life-being **that went to Ya'akov in Egypt** , those who came out from his loins, except for the wives of Ya'akov, every life-being: **sixty and six** .

27 And the sons of Yoseph who were born for him in Egypt: two life-beings. Every life-being for **the house of Ya'akov that went to Egypt** : **seventy** .

Genesis 46:8-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This tribal list of 70 descendants from Yaaqov is designed with three parts: an introduction and conclusion that frame a four-part list of Yaaqov's sons from each of his four wives.

Notice the wives are listed according to number of sons, not by the order in which they were married to Yaaqov (see [Gen. 29-30](#) for details).

The list is full of challenging chronological details that don't seem to match the narrative context.

- Yehudah is said to have two grandsons by now ([Gen. 46:12](#)).
- Binyamin is said to have ten sons, but he is portrayed as a boy in the preceding narrative ([Gen. 46:21](#), compared with Gen. 42-44).

Just as in Genesis 1 and 10, the number seven is a key organizing number in this genealogy.

"It is clear that seven (and multiples thereof) is prominent in this genealogy, whose total number of entries is 70. Rachel has fourteen descendants, and Bilhah has seven. Together they have twenty-one. Together Leah and Zilpah have forty-nine descendants. The seventh son of Jacob listed in this genealogy is Gad. Gen. 29-30 (see [30:11](#)) is the only other Jacobite genealogy in which Gad is placed in the seventh position. Interestingly, the numerical value of the seventh-placed Gad is seven (g = 3; d = 4)."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1995). [The Book of Genesis, Chapters 18-50](#). Eerdmans. 598-599.

These challenges raise the question of why the narrator would want to include a genealogical list that introduced such challenges into the narrative. The answer seems to be in the fact that when the list's numbers are summarized, they lead to the number 70. This number allowed the genealogy to play a symbolic and structural role in the story.

This long list of Yaaqov's 70 descendants who go down into Egypt is matched by the list of 70 nations that come from Noah's three sons after getting off of the ark (Gen. 10). The parallel is purposeful and loaded with significance.

Noah's Descendants in Genesis 9:18-10:32	Yaaqov's Descendants in Genesis 46
A few go into the ark, but then come out and become 70 nations	70 go down into Goshen-Egypt, and are fruitful and multiply and become a great nation
Gen. 9:18-19, 10:1 The 70 nations emerge from the three sons who “come out of the ark” after the flood	Gen. 46:26 The 70 descendants who “come out of the loins of Yaaqov” and go down to Egypt during the famine
The 70 nations come from the “remnant” that was preserved through the flood	The 70 descendants are the “remnant” that will be preserved through the famine
The 70 nations are those who will experience the blessing given to the family of Abraham	The 70 descendants are the source of the divine blessing given to Abraham for the nations
<i>Noah's and Jacob's Descendants. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

“The list of names in these verses appears to have been selected to total 'seventy' ([46:27](#)). It can hardly go without notice that the number of nations in [Genesis 10](#) is also 'seventy.' Just as the 'seventy nations' represent all the descendants of Adam, so now the 'seventy sons' represent all the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—the children of Israel. Here in narrative form is a demonstration of the theme in [Deuteronomy 32:8](#) that God apportioned the boundaries of the nations (Gen. 10) according to the number of the children of Israel. Thus the writer has gone to great lengths to portray the new nation of Israel as a new humanity and Abraham as a second Adam. The blessing that is to come through Abraham and his seed is a restoration of the original blessing of Adam, a blessing which was lost in the Fall. The picture of God that emerges from these pages is not merely a God who works with his own chosen people for their good alone, but also a God who works with the nations to bring about his plan of salvation and blessing.”

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 225.

Reflection Question

What is significant about the connection between the 70 descendants of Yaaqov and the list of the 70 nations in [Genesis 10](#)?